of Pakistan, leaving the world to understand that Iran would not hesitate to cooperate with Pakistan to suppress any separatist movement that might raise its head in Balochistan.

But the new republican government of Afghanistan, following the military coup in July 1973, showed a renewed interest in the Pakhtoonistan movement. While Pakistan considered issues relating to the NWFP and Balochistan domestic matters, at the non-aligned conference held at Algiers, Afghan delegates raised the issue of Pakistan's arrests of Pakhtoon and Baloch leaders.

The Afghan leaders knew that if Pakhtoon-istan merged with Afghanistan, the landlocked country's dependence on Pakistan for transit to and from the sea would end. India tacitly supported such a move, but Afghanistan in the late 1970s was economically and militarily not strong enough to pull off liberating a part of Pakistan the way India had done in the east. Also, the USA and the Soviet Union, who were both interested in the region, let it be known that they would not endorse such a step. In the absence of external support and internal cohesion, the chances of the Pakhtoonistan movement realising its aspirations were not very bright, but it survived because of a cultural and linguistic consciousness and a little support from Afghanistan and India. The Indian government knew the advantage of having eyes and ears on the ground and to ensure that the R&AW became a formidable intelligence organisation in the region, hundreds of informers and field agents were hired. According to R&AW documents, when Afghanistan's Khalq Democratic Party celebrated its fourteenth anniversary on 1 January 1979, the Indian spy agency's chief N.F. Suntook decided to step up operations in the region and R&AW officers were told to recruit Uzbek and Shia warlords. They spotted